

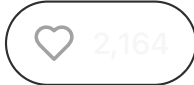
Cowork.

How to set up Claude (to level up from ChatGPT):



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MAR 04, 2026



You just switched from ChatGPT to Claude. But you're still not using Cowork. When Claude released it, software stocks lost \$830 billion in 6 days because And since I published my guide '**Claude**' (my most-shared newsletter I've written, over +2,000 shares), people keep asking me:

"I installed Claude. But how do I actually start using Claude Cowork?"

If you don't code, you must master Claude Cowork now.

First, you might be lost between different Claude modes. So here's a quick



Claude: Chat vs Cowork vs Projects

Same AI. Three different ways to use it. Here's how to pick:

Chat

What it is: You type, Claude answers. Like a chatbot.

Access: Browser, phone, or desktop app.

Setup: Zero. Open and start typing.

Cowork

Claude sits on your desktop. It reads your files, creates new ones.

Desktop app only (click the Cowork tab)

~10 minutes. Download app, pick a folder, add your files.

Projects

A saved workspace. You upload your stuff once, Claude remembers it.

Browser, phone, or desktop app.

~5 minutes. Create a project, upload files, write instructions.

Chat:

The skill you need: clear prompts

Output quality: generic unless you prompt very well

The vibe: texting a very smart stranger

Cowork:

The skill you need: clear context files (your style, your rules, your examples)

Output quality: sounds like you. Because it read your files.

The vibe: working with an assistant you read every brief

Projects:

The skill you need: picking the right files and clear instructions

Output quality: sounds like you. Because it has your guides.

The vibe: a team member who knows your playbook

What it can do:

Chat

Cowork

Projects

Answer questions	Yes	Yes	Yes
Create real files (Excel, Word, Slides, PDF)	Yes. Files can be saved or downloaded	Yes. Files appear in your folders, ready to open.	Yes. Files can be saved or downloaded
Build interactive things (calculators, trackers, charts)	Yes, via Artifacts	Yes, via Artifacts	Yes, via Artifacts
Use plugins (extra skills for sales, marketing, data)	No	Yes, install from a library. Use slash commands.	No
Connect to your tools (Slack, Google Drive, Notion)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Search the internet	Yes	Yes	Yes
Think before answering (Extended Thinking)	Yes, you turn it on manually	On by default	Yes, you turn it on manually

Start with Chat if...

Use Cowork when...

Set up a Project when...

- You have a quick question.
- You want to brainstorm.
- You don't need it to know your style.
- You want an answer, fast.

- You're doing real work (analysis, spreadsheets).
- You want Claude to create actual files.
- You want it to sound like you, not AI.
- You need long, deep sessions that don't break.

- You do the same task every week (newsletter, reports).
- You're tired of repeating yourself.
- You want your context saved forever, not just for one session.

	CHAT	COWORK	PROJECTS
YOUR IDENTITY	No. Every chat starts blank.	Yes, if you put info about yourself in text files inside your folder.	Yes, from the files and instructions you added to the project.
CONTEXT INPUT	You copy-paste into the chat. Every. Single. Time.	You write .md or .txt files once. Drop them in a folder. Point Claude to it.	You upload files and write instructions once. They stick.
CONTEXT BETWEEN CHATS	No. Gone when you start a new chat.	Yes, as long as you're in the same folder.	Yes. Every new chat inside the project has it.

Quick tasks: Chat

Deep sessions: Cowork

Recurring work: Projects or Cowork

Claude Cowork and Projects both need a Pro Plan (\$20/mo). Cowork is desktop only. Extended thinking works everywhere - always turn it on.

+

Opus 4.6 Extended

↑

to download more infographics, go to [how-to-ai.guide](#)

from [Ruben Hassid](#), on "How to AI"

And that's not it.

<https://ruben.substack.com/p/claude-cowork>

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Here's the entire Claude product line, in short:

Claude "Chat" → it's like ChatGPT. Probably the only one you know.

Claude "Project" → it's still Claude Chat, but separated as individual

Claude "Code" → massive revolution for developers to code (much) faster

Claude "Cowork" → like Claude Code but for us, knowledge workers.

Claude "Skills" → teach Claude repeatable workflows. Like better Productivity

Claude "Connectors" → plug Claude directly into apps like Slack, Google Calendar, Gmail, etc. It reads, writes, and acts inside the tools you already use.

Claude "Plugins" → like Connectors, but you do it (you don't want the Connectors = download from the App Store, Plugins = you upload your own)

This newsletter is the full playbook of Cowork. How to set it up. How I use every single week to write this newsletter, deliver consulting work, and rest faster than I ever could alone. Also, where it falls short (*I keep promising how*

Two things before we start:

1. Save this guide and spend 30 minutes this weekend to explore Cowork.
2. Send it to anyone who still hasn't tried Cowork (or Claude).

You must forget about prompts.

You read my **Claude** guide. So you installed it correctly.

Just a quick reminder for those who didn't read it:

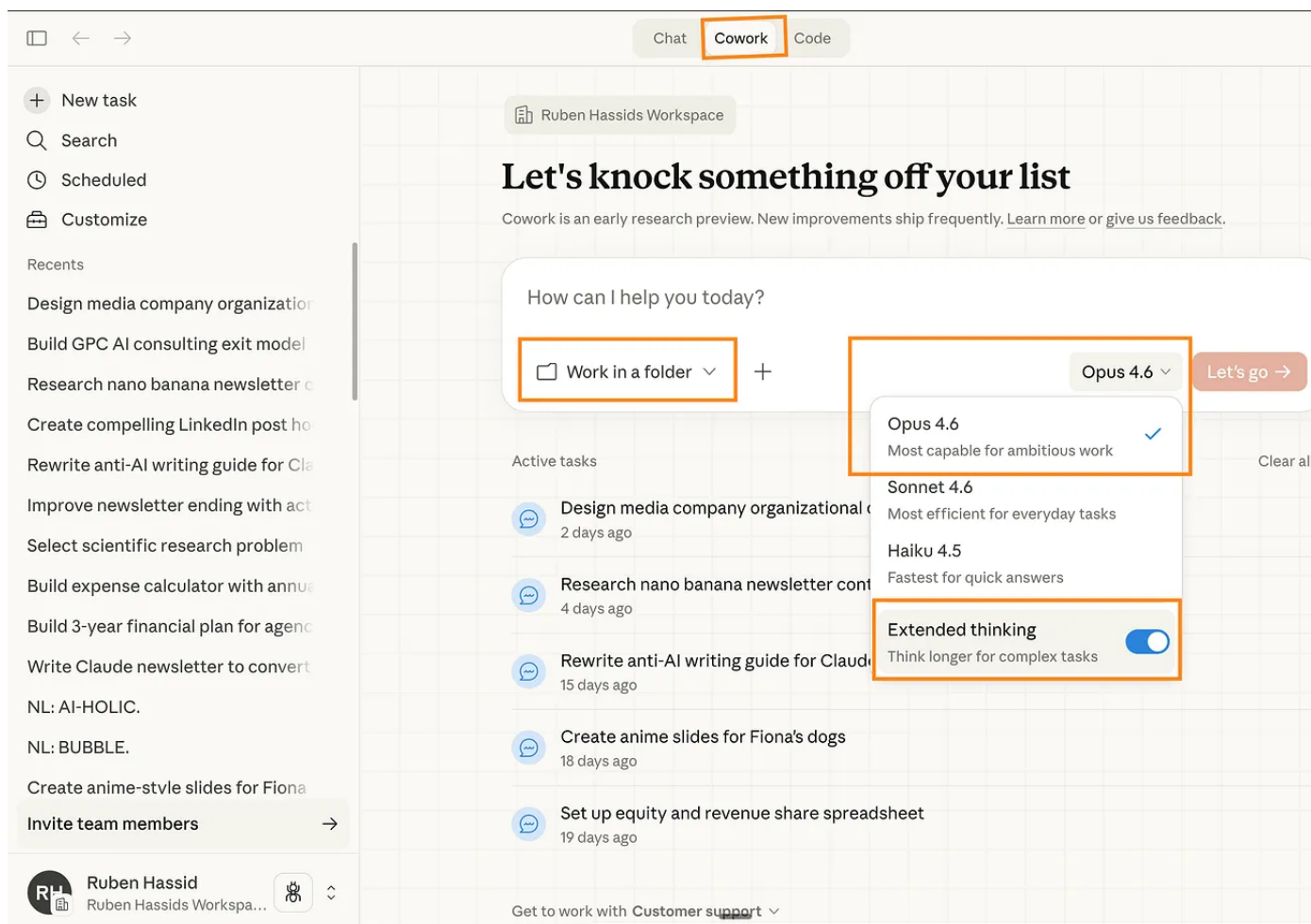
Go to claude.com/download. Download the app.

You need a Pro account (\$20/month). It's very much worth it.

Open the app. Click on the Cowork tab at the top between Chat & Code

Select a folder from your computer. More about it right after this set up

Make sure to always select "Opus 4.6" and "Extended thinking".



This is the Claude app (installed on your computer). Make sure to go to the Cowork tab > Select Opus 4.6 + Extended thinking > Work in a folder.

ChatGPT trained you to write better prompts. Longer prompts. Forget the

With Cowork, the game is text files. Take everything you know (your writi

your company's rules, your best examples, your past work) and put it in text files. Drop them in a folder. Point Claude to that folder.

It's kind of like having an SOP for an employee. But here, Claude is your employee. And the SOP is your "Claude Cowork" folder.

The more context you give it as files, the less prompting you need. The output goes from "generic AI" to "this actually sounds like a full-time employee."

Here's how to create your folder:

Step 1: Build your folder.

Create a dedicated folder for Cowork on your computer.

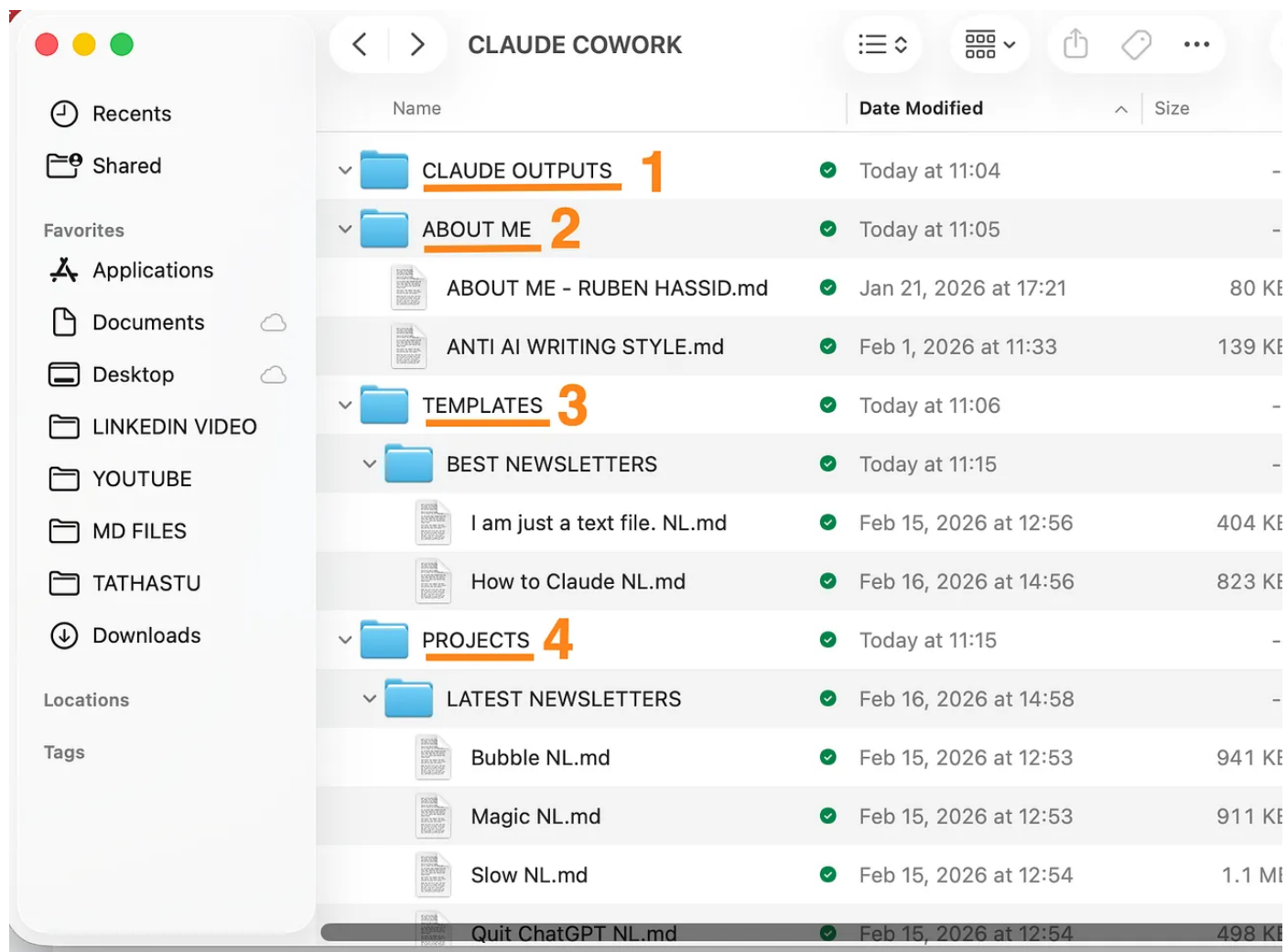
It needs a clean, intentional space. Here's mine:

ABOUT ME → a folder with 1/ "about me", 2/ "anti AI writing style".

PROJECTS → live work. The **projects** you're building right now. The briefs, drafts, the reference material for that specific job. one subfolder per project.

TEMPLATES → finished work so good you want to reuse it as a pattern. not the content itself, but the "perfect" structure, as **templates**.

CLAUDE OUTPUTS → where Claude Cowork delivers finished work.



Parent folder: CLAUDE COWORK. Inside, there are 4x folders (1-2-3-4).

This keeps things organized and limits what Claude can see. Cowork has 1 read/write access to whatever folder you share. If something goes wrong, y the damage contained. You must keep it tight.

Now here's how to create your own core files:

Step 2: Create your core files.

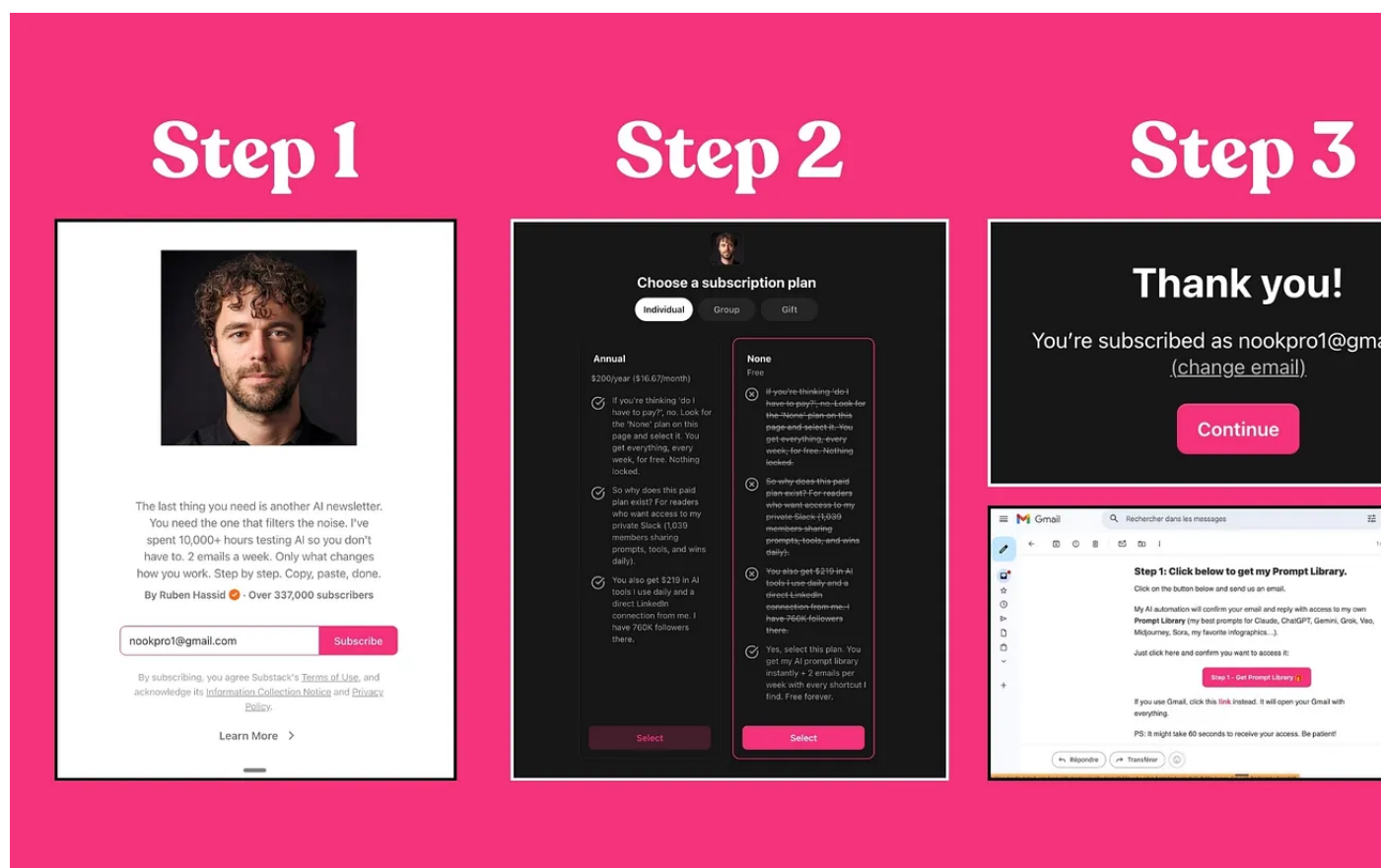
You now have 4 folders within your mega "Claude Cowork" folder.

Let's create the "About me" files now:

File 1: about-me.md — Who you are. What you do. Your current priorities matters to you right now. I wrote an entire newsletter on **how to do it**.

File 2: anti-ai-writing-style.md — Because I hate the AI style. So I made a on how to NEVER write like an AI. I share how to download it below.

Download my 3x md files by **subscribing** to my newsletter for free. Do not anything. Open my welcome email & you will access my Notion doc with 1

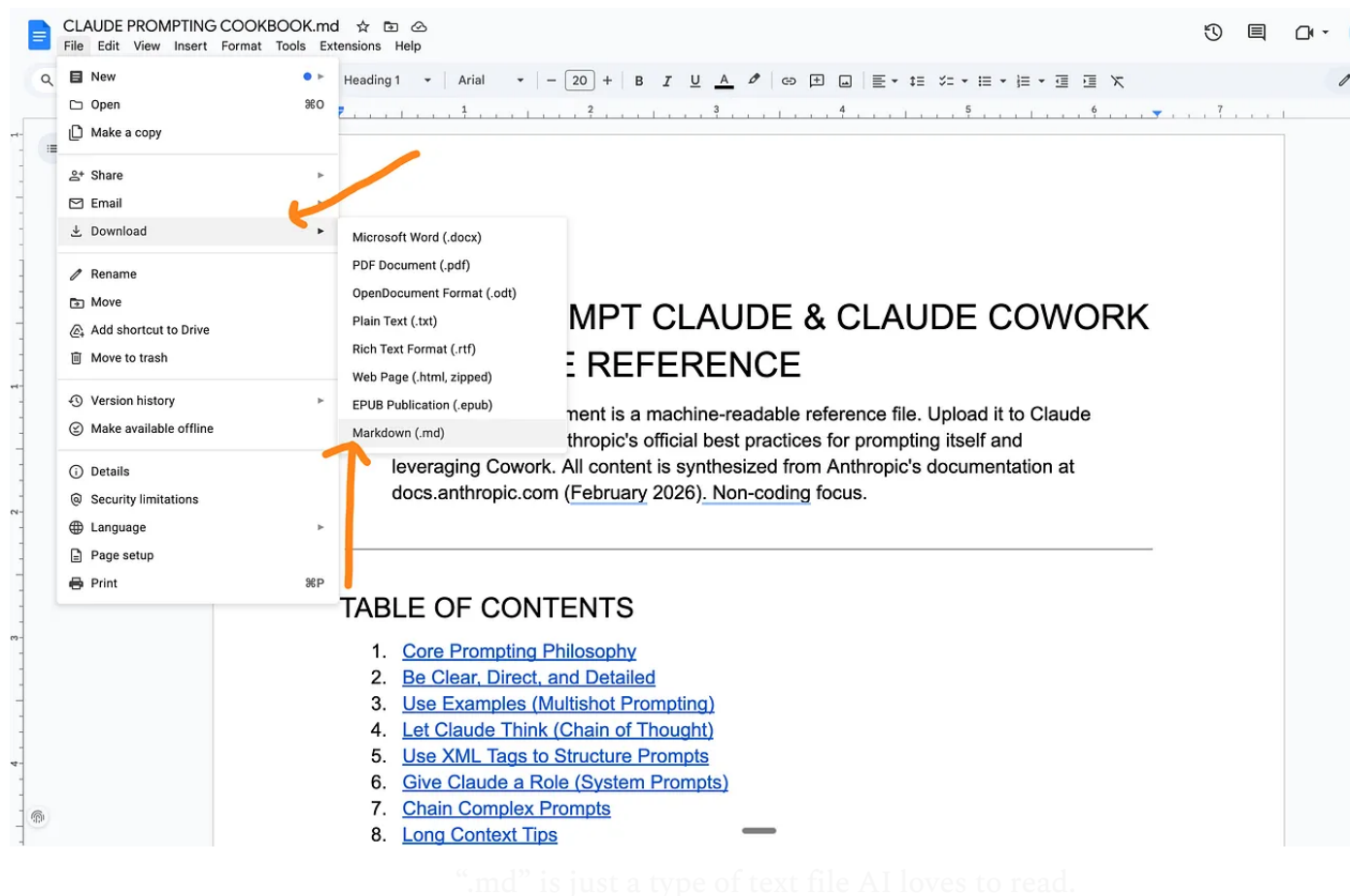


1 - Leave your email 2 - Select "None" to not pay 3 - Open the welcome email to confirm your subscription 4 - Receive my prompt & md files entire library.

If you are free subscribers already, and can't find this email, leave a co

Quick note: a markdown file is just a plain text file with an .md extension. any text editor (even a Google Doc works), write your content, and save it as

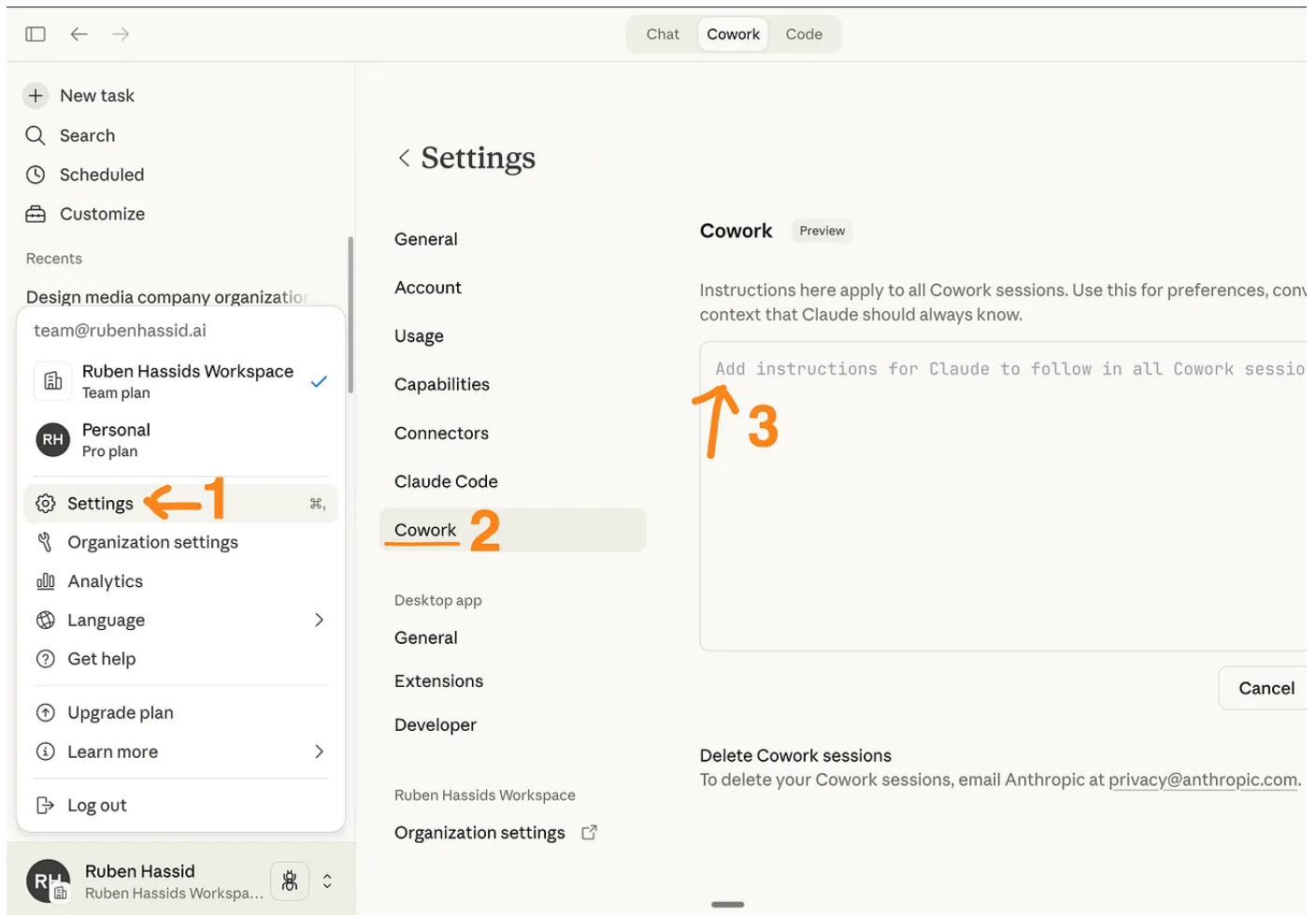
me.md instead of about-me.txt. Claude reads them better.



One great markdown file is worth more than 50 random uploads. Don't dump everything into the folder. Be intentional about what you include.

Step 3: Set Global Instructions.

Go to: Settings → Cowork → Edit Global Instructions.



It's like a persistent prompt Claude Cowork always read before.

Global Instructions handle how Claude must (always) behave.

Paste this:

```
# GLOBAL INSTRUCTIONS
```

```
## BEFORE EVERY TASK
```

1. Read `ABOUT ME/`. No task starts without reading both.
2. If the task relates to a project, read everything in the matching `PROJECTS/` subfolder before proceeding.
3. If the task involves a content type that has a matching pattern in `TEMPLATES/`

study that template's structure first. Use the structure. Don't copy the content.

FOLDER PROTOCOL

You have three read-only folders and one write folder.

Read-only – never create, edit, or delete anything here:

- `ABOUT ME/` → My identity and writing rules.
- `TEMPLATES/` → Proven structures to reuse as patterns.
- `PROJECTS/` → My briefs, references, and finished work organized by project.

Write folder – the only place you deliver work:

- `CLAUDE OUTPUTS/` → Everything you create goes here. Organize with one subfolder per project, mirroring the structure of `PROJECTS/`. Create the subfolder if it doesn't exist yet.

NAMING CONVENTION

All files you create must follow this format:

`project\_content-type\_v1.ext`

Content types: Newsletter, LinkedIn Post, Brief, Deck, Report.

Examples:

- `How-To-AI\_Newsletter\_v1.md`
- `EasyGen\_Deck\_v1.pptx`
- `GPC\_Report\_v2.docx`

Increment the version number if a file with the same name already exists.

OPERATING RULES

- If the brief is unclear or incomplete, use the `AskUserQuestion` tool. Don't fill gaps with generic filler.
- Don't over-explain. Deliver the work. Save the commentary unless I ask for it.
- Never delete files anywhere.

You set this once. It runs every time. You never type it again.

Combined with your context files, this means your prompts can be 10 words and still produce work that sounds like you. With the same level of quality

Here's a prompt example:

I want to write a cold DM on LinkedIn to a Chief of Staff who needs an AI workshop.

I will DM her on LinkedIn, and I need to have a clear strategy to make her open the message and book a call.

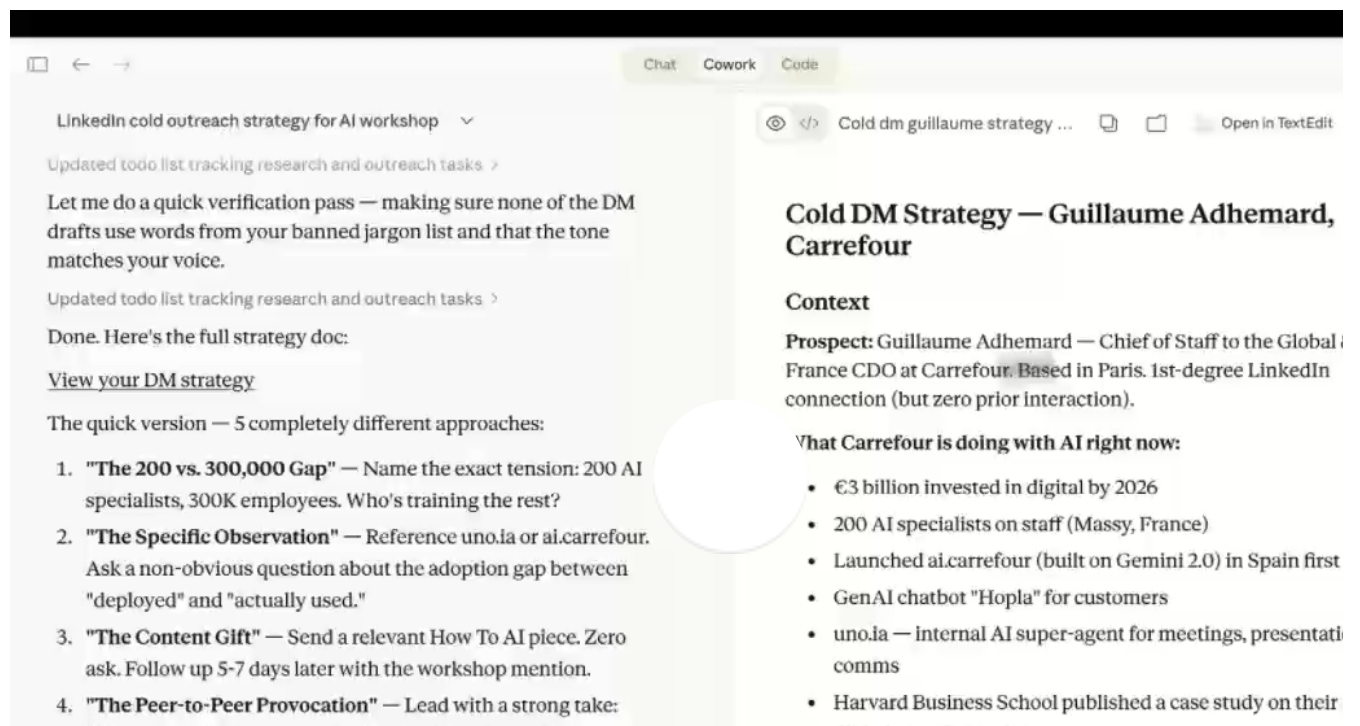
Start by using AskUserQuestion. Develop 5x completely different strategies.

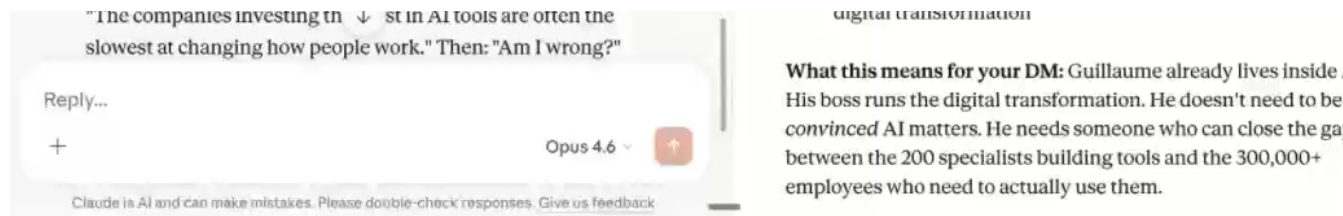
1. Use Cowork
2. Select your Claude folder
3. Select the right model
4. Straightforward prompt with the task + success criteria + steps.

Claude Cowork asked me clarifying questions, and I clicked on my answers.

It works like an employee to complete the task.

It takes 1-7 minutes, but I usually work somewhere else (or spin up more sessions on my browser with Claude Chat - welcome to the new world).





This level of output is literally what a good employee would do.

Now extrapolate to legal work, creative agencies, academic research.

You might think it was “too simple of a benchmark”.

Alright, let’s do another example. A heavy Excel file together:

I want to create a spreadsheet that maps out a potential exit for my socials (if I could sell them). Start by using AskUserQuestion to be up to date with my numbers

Then and only then, create a spreadsheet with Wall Street financial model style.

It plans itself. It finds error itself. It fixes itself... while I work on something else. This is the revolution I was mentioning earlier.

Few question, 2 minutes. And I have a perfect start to an Excel file.

If you're curious about the one-shot results (I didn't change anything from answer), go here:

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1WkUTtE41zdHT616a2zLxLtoC79DLJGi5tr_Fk/edit?usp=sharing.

Don't prompt Claude. Let it prompt you.

This is the feature that changed how I work. And I haven't seen a single C guide explain it properly.

Always add this to your prompt:

Start by using the AskUserQuestion tool before answering to gather enough context

When you do this, Cowork generates an interactive form. Actual buttons. Clickable options. Multi-select choices. Rankings you can drag and reorder

AI is finally prompt *you*.

Here, my prompt is literally 2 lines + my Claude Cowork folder. That's it.

I often times write the answer myself. But the options give me a direction.

“Nobody followed you because of your breakfast” is taken from my “about me” file. I can now build up from here.

This is called **AskUserQuestion**. It’s a tool built into Cowork. Claude *forces* be clear. It asks the right questions so it can give you the right output.

The one prompt I use for everything.

80% of my chats with Cowork starts like this:

I want to [TASK] to [SUCCESS CRITERIA].

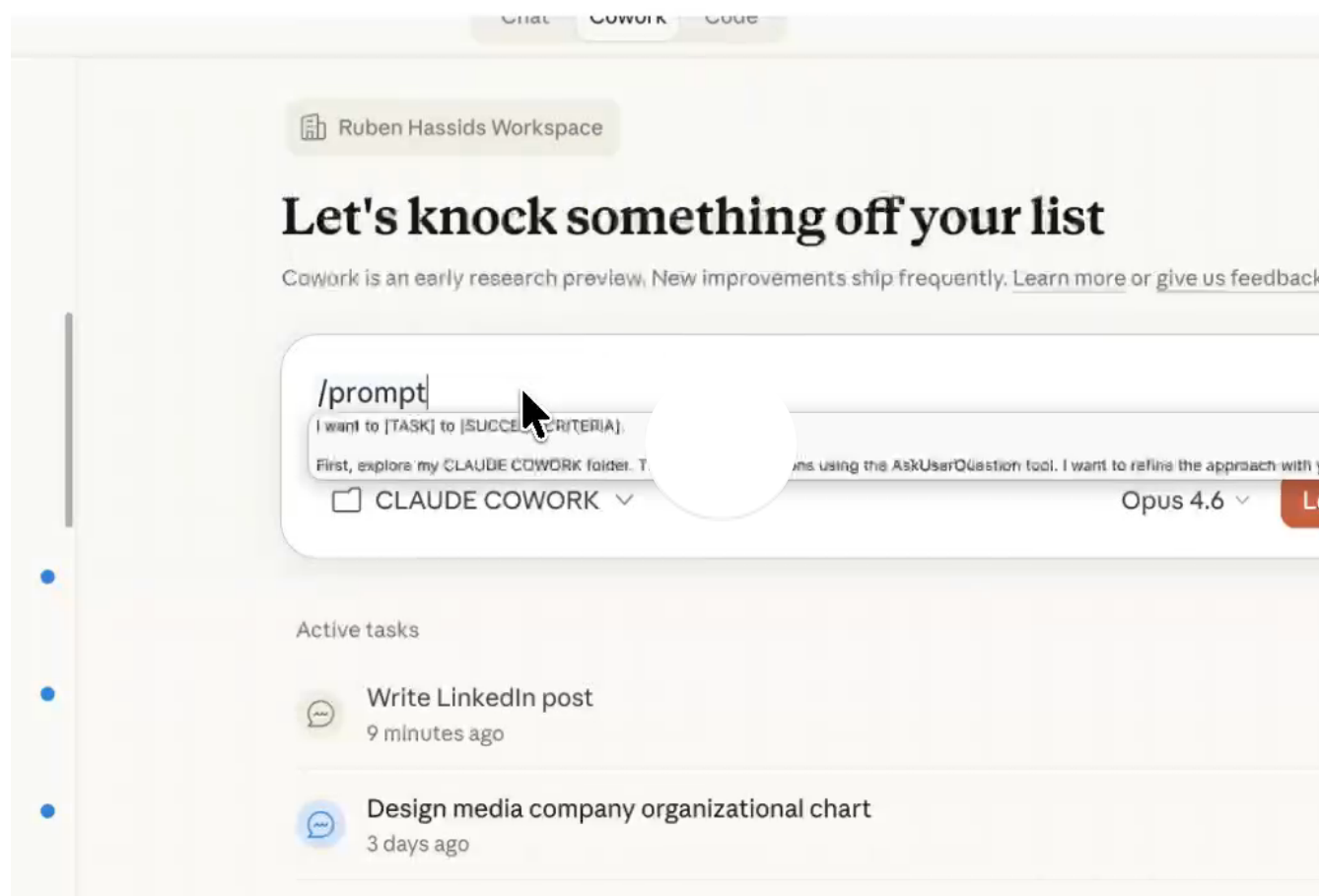
First, explore my CLAUDE COWORK folder. Then, ask me questions using the AskUserQuestion tool. I want to refine the approach with you before you execute.

What happens: Claude reads your context files, generates a clickable form about your audience, your goals, your preferences. You click through in under a minute. Claude shows a plan. You approve. It executes — creating real files in your folder. If something's off midway, you interrupt. Claude recalibrates with a new form. Picks up where it left off.

The entire process feels like directing someone smart instead of wrestling a text box. I'm obsessed with this feature.

(Yes, I stopped writing prompts. My prompt folder is collecting dust.)

I even added a “Text Replacement” on my Mac so that whenever I am typing the command “/prompt” it pastes this one prompt:



If you use a Mac, search for “Text replacement”. Click on the “+” and si
add a command (I like `/prompt`) and paste my prompt template.

How to use Plugins inside Cowork.

Remember that \$830 billion stock crash I opened with?

Anthropic released 11 official plugins. Sales. Marketing. Legal. Finance. D
analysis. Product management. Customer support. Each one gives Claude
skills, workflows, and slash commands for that function.

Legal software lost so much value because Claude can *do the work*. And the
sitting in your Cowork sidebar are a big part of what triggered that reactio

You don't need to be technical to install it. I promise.

How to install:

1. Open Cowork.
2. Click **Customize** in the left sidebar → Browse plugins.
3. Pick one that matches your work. Install.
4. Type `/` in the chat to see available slash commands.

On the homepage, click on “Customize”.

Can't make it clearer for you, my friend :)

Browse, and click “Install” on the ones you want to try. It’s free.

Now click on the “+”, go to Plugins > [Name of the plugin] > Subtask.

Or you just learn the /command (here /onboarding).

You can even customize each plugins based on your company (Claude will ask you questions, and it will remember the answers).

What this looks like in practice:

Marketing plugin

The prompt: */marketing:draft-content* → “Write a LinkedIn post about [topic] my voice profile. Target [audience].”

What happens: Claude reads your about-me.md, drafts a post that actually like you, and suggests hook variations. You pick one, edit, post. Five minu

instead of thirty.

Data plugin

The prompt: `/data:explore` → Drop a CSV into the folder.

What happens: Claude summarizes every column, flags anomalies, suggests analyses, and can build an interactive dashboard. It writes SQL in plain English. You don't touch a formula.

Legal plugin

The prompt: "Review the NDA in this folder. Flag anything unusual or one."

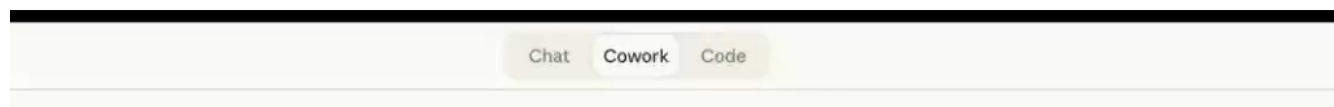
What happens: Claude reads the contract, highlights risky clauses, explains one in plain English, and suggests alternative language. This is what wiped a billion off the stock market.

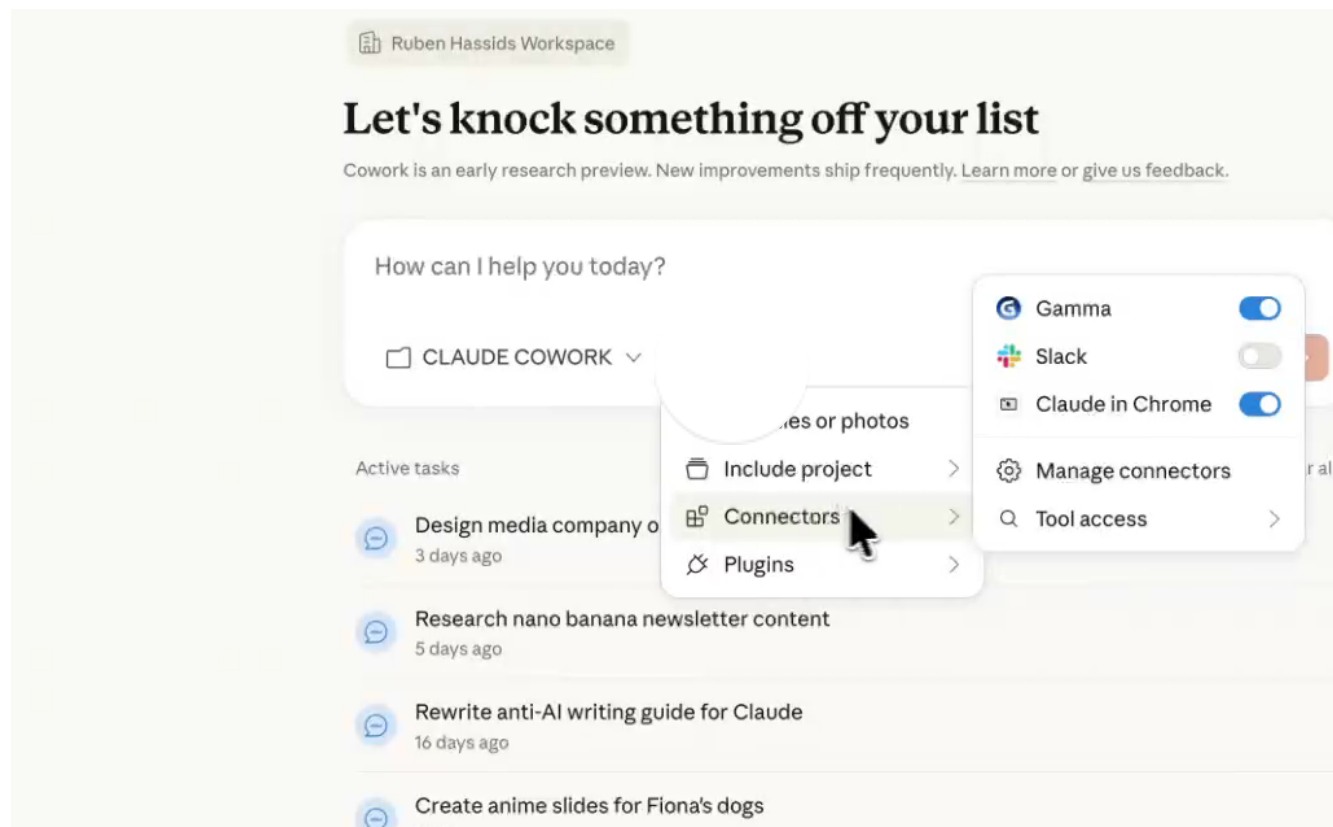
Connectors: Claude, inside your tools.

Cowork can also connect to your existing tools. Slack, Google Drive, Notion, Figma, and 50+ others. They're called Connectors.

Go to **Settings** → **Connectors**. Browse the directory. Click "Add." Done.

Once connected, it reads your tools. Claude can search your Slack messages from your Google Docs, or reference your Notion pages mid-conversation.





Here's an example with Gamma.

Oh, and I forgot - connectors are free.

How I actually use Cowork every day.

I don't use anything else these days.

Use case 1: Writing this newsletter.

The setup: My folder has my about-me.md, my anti-AI-writing-guide.md, newsletters that performed well, reference guides from other creators, and documentation from companies (like OpenAI/Anthropic/Google).

The prompt:

```
I want to write my next newsletter on using Gemini to grow on LinkedIn with infographics using the new Nano Banana 2.
```

```
First, explore my CLAUDE COWORK folder. Then, ask me questions using the AskUserQuestion tool. I want to refine the approach with you before you execute.
```

What happens: Claude reads every file. Generates a form asking about my audience, my tone, what length, what angles the other guides missed. I click answers. It produces an outline. I push back on weak sections. It adjusts. It writes — and because it has my voice profile and anti-AI writing guide, it actually sounds like me.*

I edit. But the heavy lifting is done. This newsletter you're reading right now outlined by Cowork and written by me. But you don't care and you keep re

**look, he used an em-dash, it must be AI!!! no i did it on purpose.*

Use case 2: Consulting deliverables.

The setup: Client sends a brief. I drop it in the folder next to my templates past deliverables.

The prompt:

```
A client just sent a brief for a 2026 AI adoption strategy. The brief is in /projects/client-x/.
```

```
Read the brief, my deliverable template, and my past examples.
```

Create a first draft as a .docx. Ask me questions first (AskUserQuestion).

What happens: Claude reads the brief. Compares it to my template format. It asks me things I didn't think of — *"Should this include a timeline or just recommendations?"* and *"Do you want competitor examples or keep it internal?"* and answers. It creates a .docx file directly in my folder.

Use case 3: Research and competitive analysis.

The setup: I drop 3-5 competitor articles or reports into a subfolder.

The prompt:

I uploaded 4 newsletters from other creators covering Claude Cowork. Read all of them. Create a comparison table: what each one covered, what they missed, and where I could be the only one saying something new. Ask me questions first.

What happens: That used to be a junior job in my company. Now it's a process.

Use case 4: Automated weekly briefing.

This one is different. Cowork works *without you even being there*.

The setup: You create a folder called /weekly-briefings/.

The prompt (with /schedule, it's a plugin):

Every Monday at 7am, research [competitor names] for news, product updates, or price changes. Save a summary to /weekly-briefings/ as a markdown file. Only include it from the past 7 days.

What happens: Cowork runs automatically every Monday, as long as your computer is awake and the app is open. You wake up to a briefing doc read. That's the endgame.

Across all four use cases, the pattern is the same. I never write a long prompt. I write a short task, point to my folder, and say "ask me questions."

The workflow is always the same. Only the context changes.

Where Cowork falls short (I promised honesty).

It eats your usage fast. A single Cowork session can burn through what would normally be dozens of regular chat conversations. On the Pro plan (\$20/month) you'll feel it within a week if you use it daily. If Cowork becomes your main workflow, consider Max (\$100/month). I'm being direct about this because I don't want you surprised.

It's still a research preview. Anthropic says this explicitly. It can make mistakes. It can misread files. It sometimes takes an odd approach to a task when a simpler one would work. You need to review what it produces. Don't send a client deliverable without reading it first.

It needs the app open. Close the Claude Desktop app, and the session dies. There's no mobile version. No web version. Cowork only runs inside the desktop app on macOS or Windows.

It's not for quick questions. If you want to ask "what's the capital of France?"

Chat. Cowork is for tasks, not trivia. It's designed for multi-step work.

Agents can be hit or miss. For complex tasks, Cowork breaks the work into chunks and runs them in parallel using multiple agents. Most of the time, it's fast and accurate. Sometimes one agent goes in a weird direction, and the final output is a section that doesn't match the rest. Keep an eye on it. Happens 10% of the time.

Cowork is not the best at everything. But it's getting better every week.

And if this is Claude Opus 4.6 + Cowork, I can't imagine Claude 5, Claude

Your first 30 minutes with Cowork.

Open your calendar. Book 30 minutes with yourself, this newsletter, and Cowork.

Minutes 0–5: Install and open Cowork.

- Go to claude.com/download. Download the desktop app.
- Sign in with your Pro account (\$20/month. Or \$17/month if you pay annually).
- Open the app. Click the Cowork tab at the top.
- You're in.

Minutes 5–10: Build your context folder.

- Create a folder on your computer called "Claude-Cowork." Inside it, create subfolders: ABOUT ME, TEMPLATES, PROJECTS, CLAUDE OUTPUT.
- In the **context** folder, create your first file: *about-me.md*. Write three things about you.

What you do for work. (2) How you like to communicate. (3) One example of writing you're proud of. Paste it in.

→ No time to write it yourself? Skip to minute 10 and let Cowork create it

Pro tip: Instead of typing, use **Wispr Flow** to talk. It's 4x faster.

Minutes 10–15: Start your first Cowork conversation.

→ In Cowork, click **Add Folder** and select your Claude-Cowork folder.

→ Make sure to select Opus 4.6 + Extended thinking for the smartest AI.

→ Type: *"I want [task] for [success criteria]. Go through my folder first, and use AskUserQuestion tool so you gather enough content before executing."*

→ Watch what happens. A form appears. Click answers. Let it create your files.

Minutes 15–20: Install a plugin.

→ Click **Customize** in the sidebar → Browse plugins.

→ Pick one that fits your work. Good starters: *Productivity* (tasks and work *Marketing* (content drafting), or *Sales* (prospect research).

→ Click to install. Start a new conversation with the plugin active.

→ Type / to see what slash commands are available. Try one.

Minutes 20-30: Create a tough deliverable.

→ Give Cowork a task you'd actually need for work this week.

→ Type: *“Create a [report / deck / document] based on the files in this folder. Ask questions first.”*

→ Watch it create a real file. Open it. Edit it. Use it.

→ Optional: be amazed.

I don't care about Claude.

I don't care about Claude, ChatGPT, Grok, Gemini, or any other model.

I don't pick sides. I'm not paid to make this newsletter.

I'm sharing, twice a week, how my work is transforming (*very fast*) with AI.

As I'm trying to keep up, I want *you* to keep up. So we move just as fast.

I want to be the greatest filter to the AI noise. And 338,000+ people read this a week to focus on the **How**. Some came because of my LinkedIn. But most readers subscribed because someone they trusted sent one of my articles to them.

If this article helped you, **be that person for someone else** (and share it):

It does not cost you anything to share. And sharing is caring :)

If someone did send you this, thank them and subscribe for free here:

archive of my past blogs:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1pWuMCBVQo1zKcgKltX_BZxAr31KgxmOlp3Vzvmc5Hxcusp/sharing



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Write a comment...



ToxSec

Mar 4

♥ Liked by Ruben Hassid

fantastic read! i've personally been a big fan of cowork. i think anthropic is really putting top notch products with this release. glad it made its way to windows. that's for all the

♥ LIKE (21)

💬 REPLY

2 replies by Ruben Hassid and others



Breadman7

Mar 5

♥ Liked by Ruben Hassid

This was an amazing read again, elevating my ai game day by day with you Ruben. Can files though:/

♥ LIKE (9)

💬 REPLY

7 replies by Ruben Hassid and others

835 more comments...

